

1.1.3 Background

The period leading up to the start of this specification has been a difficult one for post-16 mathematics with a substantial drop in the numbers taking the subject. This specification has been designed to redress that situation by ensuring that the various units can indeed be taught and learnt within the time allocated.

Considerable thought has gone into its design, and from a large number of people, many of them classroom teachers or lecturers. Those responsible are confident that the specification makes full use of the new opportunities opened up by the changes to the subject criteria: mathematics will be accessible to many more students but will also provide sufficient challenge for the most able.

MEI Structured Mathematics was first introduced in 1990 and was subsequently refined in 1994 and 2000 to take account of new subject cores and advice from teachers and lecturers. The philosophy underlying the 1990 specification was described in its introduction, which is reproduced verbatim later in this section.

This specification represents a new interpretation of the same philosophy. It takes account not only of the requirements of the 2002 subject criteria but also of the quite different environment in which post-16 mathematics is now embedded.

The major changes from the previous MEI specification (that for first teaching in September 2000) are outlined for the convenience of users on page 8 of this specification. However, it is more appropriate to see this as a specification in its own right, which, while building on past experience, is designed for present-day students working in present-day conditions.